

RESTORATION DRAMA ANALYSIS

Negotiating Independence

The Modernity of the Proviso Scene in William Congreve's *The Way of the World* (1700)

CONTEXTUALIZING ACT IV

The 1700 Marriage Market

Transitioning from feudal patriarchal control to early modern notions of a "voluntary compact" in Restoration London high society.

Millamant's Demands: **Sovereignty**

Preserving the "Self"

Millamant refuses to be legally swallowed. She demands boundaries: the liberty to write and receive letters freely, to maintain separate friendships, and to have absolute sovereignty over her private chambers.

Banishing "Nauseous Cant"

She strictly forbids performative conjugal pet names like "wife, spouse, joy, or jewel" in public. For Millamant, these sentimental tags mask a real loss of identity and degrade mutual respect.

Mirabell's Counter-Provisos: **Sincerity**

- ◆ **Dismantling Social Affectation:** Mirabell targets the superficial, performative traps of London high society to negotiate an authentic union.
- ◆ **Physical and Biological Truth:** He prohibits toxic, lead-heavy cosmetics and explicitly bans restrictive, tight corsets during pregnancy.
- ◆ **Defining Conjugal Honesty:** By restricting gossips, fops, and deceptive confidants, he demands a real human partner, not an empty courtly doll.



Restoration High Society & Social Performative Costumes

The Paradox of Courtship

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*"My dear liberty, shall I leave thee? ... I may by degrees
dwindle into a wife."*

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— Millamant, Act IV, Scene i

The Modernity of the Compact

Lockean Shift

John Locke's 1689 philosophy redefines marital relations as a "voluntary compact" between equals.

Modern Liberty

The text anticipates modern partnership dynamics emphasizing mutual respect and private boundaries.

Feudal Contract

Marriages viewed as family property agreements with total subjection under coverture laws.

Congreve's Drama

The 1700 Proviso Scene turns legalistic negotiation into a defense shield for romantic liberty.

Questions & Discussion

"How does surviving 'the way of the world' require us to negotiate our identities?"

Restoration and Late 17th Century Literature | Presentation by Student

Image Sources



https://sites.udel.edu/britlitwiki/files//2018/06/Drury_Lane_Theatre.jpg

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